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**ROBIN HOBB'S «THE WORLD OF THE ELDERING»
ONOMASTICON: THE STRUCTURAL AND FUNCTIONAL
SIGNIFICANCE OF CHARACTONYMS**

Abstract. The article is devoted to a comprehensive functional and semantic analysis of charactonyms within the literary universe created by the prominent American fantasy writer Robin Hobb in her renowned series *The World of the Elderlings*. In literary texts, proper names lose their purely identifying real-world function and transform into multi-layered linguistic tools intentionally designed by authors to encode deep narrative meanings, establish socio-cultural contexts, outline psychological profiles, and steer readers' aesthetic perception. This study addresses a notable gap in contemporary literary onomastics, as Hobb's intricate onomastic space has remained largely unexplored despite its profound semantic and structural complexity.

The structural and functional analysis conducted in the article reveals that the onymic space of the Six Duchies is meticulously constructed upon the fundamental principle of national-cultural contrast. This artistic device serves as a primary marker of cultural differentiation: evocative, transparent, and semantically dense English-derived names function exclusively within the dominant culture of the Six Duchies, closely aligning with the diegetic concept of the magical potency embedded in a name. Conversely, representatives of neighboring nations, such as the Mountain Kingdom or Kalsid, are assigned names characterized by phonetic foreignness and an absolute lack of transparent semantics for the reader (e.g., Eyod, Rurisk, Kettricken), which strongly reinforces their cultural "otherness" and alien status within the narrative fabric.

Researcher L. Belei proposed a rigorous classification of the anthroponyms, dividing them into distinct functional-semantic subgroups: names of national or

regional significance, socially significant charactonyms, and informational-evaluative names. The study demonstrates that socially significant anthroponyms represent the most dominant and structurally diverse group, which perfectly mirrors the early medieval setting of the fantasy universe where a person's social mask, status, and destiny are inextricably linked. Key examples such as Chivalry, Regal, Fitz, and The Fool are analyzed to illustrate how names indicate royal legitimacy, political ambitions, or severe societal stigma. Furthermore, informational-evaluative charactonyms, including Shrewd, Desire, and Patience, are investigated as tools of direct psychological characterization that explicitly encapsulate the core inner nature, behavioral patterns, and moral capacities of the characters. The paper concludes that Hobb's charactonyms transcend basic nomenclature, serving as a vital mechanism of character development and world-building. Prospective areas for further scholarly scientific inquiry are identified, including expanding the linguistic analysis to other cycles of the universe and examining the translated variants of these proper names.

Keywords: literary onomastics, charactonym, anthroponym, Robin Hobb, *The World of the Elderlings*, fantasy literature, functional-semantic analysis.

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ОНОМАСТИКОН «СВІТУ ЕЛДЕРЛІНГІВ» РОБІН ГОББ: СТРУКТУРНО-ФУНКЦІОНАЛЬНЕ ЗНАЧЕННЯ ХАРАКТЕРОНІМІВ

Анотація. Стаття присвячена комплексному функціонально-семантичному аналізу характеронімів у літературному всесвіті відомої американської письменниці Робін Гобб «Світ Елдерлінгів». У художньому тексті власна назва втрачає свою виключно ідентифікаційну функцію, притаманну реальному світу, і трансформується у багатовимірний лінгвістичний інструмент, свідомо обраний автором для кодування глибинних наративних змістів, окреслення психологічного профілю персонажів та моделювання читацького сприйняття. Актуальність дослідження зумовлена стрімким розвитком фентезійної літератури та недостатнім



ступенем вивченості ономастичного простору творів Робін Гобб у сучасній вітчизняній та світовій літературній ономастиці, попри значну семантичну та структурну складність цього матеріалу.

У результаті дослідження з'ясовано, що ономастичний простір Шести Герцогств вибудований за фундаментальним принципом національно-культурного контрасту. Цей художній прийом виступає основним маркером культурної диференціації у творах письменниці: промовисті, семантично прозорі та насичені назви, що мають чітку внутрішню форму в англійській мові, використовуються виключно в межах панівної культури Шести Герцогств. Це безпосередньо пов'язано з центральним сюжетотворчим концептом магічної сили імені в досліджуваному фентезійному всесвіті. Натомість представники інших етносів (наприклад, жителі Гірського Королівства чи Калсиди) наділені іменами, що характеризуються фонетичною чужорідністю та повною відсутністю прозорої семантики для читача (наприклад, *Ейод*, *Руріск*, *Кеттрікен*), що підкреслює їхню «інакшість» та статус чужинців у наративній тканині романів.

Антропоніми в романах класифіковано за функціонально-семантичними підгрупами на підставі типології, розробленої дослідником Л. Белей: імена національно-регіонального значення, соціально марковані характероніми та інформативно-оцінні ономастичні одиниці. Доведено, що соціально значущі антропоніми становлять найбільш репрезентативну та структурно різноманітну групу, що ідеально відображає ранньосередньовічний сетинг фентезійного всесвіту, де соціальна маска, статус та доля людини є нерозривно пов'язаними. На прикладі аналізу таких знакових імен, як *Чівелрі*, *Регал*, *Фітц* та *Блазень*, продемонстровано, як характероніми кодують монаршу легітимність, політичні амбіції чи, навпаки, суспільне тавро позашлюбного походження. Крім того, інформативно-оцінні характероніми (зокрема, *Шрюд*, *Дезайр*, *Пейшенс*) досліджено як засіб прямої психологічної характеристики, який експліцитно акумулює внутрішню сутність, домінантні риси характеру, паттерни поведінки та моральний потенціал персонажів. Проведений аналіз дозволяє зробити висновок, що власні імена у творчості Робін Гобб виходять за межі номінації, слугуючи ключовим механізмом текстотворення та моделювання вигаданого світу. Перспективним напрямком подальших наукових розвідок може бути розширення матеріалу дослідження на інші цикли всесвіту та порівняльний аналіз оригінальних власних назв з їхніми перекладними варіантами.

Ключові слова: літературна ономастика, характеронім, антропонім, Робін Гобб, Світ Елдерлінгів, фентезі, функціонально-семантичний аналіз.



Statement of the problem. Fiction is a unique space in which proper names take on a special functional and semantic significance. Unlike real-world proper names, which primarily serve an identifying function, charactonyms – proper names in a literary work – are linguistic units deliberately chosen by the author to shape a character's image, set the tone of the work and influence the reader's perception.

This issue is particularly relevant in the context of fantasy literature, where the author constructs not only characters and a plot, but also a complete fictional universe with its own culture, social hierarchy and onomastic space. The novels of the American writer Robin Hobb, which make up the literary universe of 'The Elderlings', are a striking example of such construction: every name in this universe carries semantic weight, reflecting the cultural, social and psychological dimensions of the society depicted.

The study of charactonyms in Robin Hobb's novels has not only a purely linguistic but also a literary significance, as it allows us to uncover the mechanisms of the author's artistic thinking and to trace how linguistic means serve as a tool for character development and the construction of the works' imagery.

Analysis of recent studies and publications. Literary onomastics has emerged as a distinct discipline at the intersection of linguistics and literary studies. The domestic tradition of literary-onomastic studies is represented by the works of Yu. O. Karpenko, who introduced the term 'poetonym' into academic discourse and defined it as a proper name in a literary text characterised by a particular connotative potential [1].

L. Beley, founder of the Uzhhorod School of Literary Onomastics, defines this as the proper names of characters that appear in literary and artistic texts [2]. M. M. Torchynskyi proposed a comprehensive classification of the onymic field based on the following criteria: the nature of the named objects, the characteristics of proper name formation, the stylistic features of proper names, and the scope and form of their usage [3].

Foreign researchers refer to proper names in literary texts as 'names in literature', which coincides with the name of the discipline that studies these names. The terminological group of the International Council of Onomastic Sciences (ICOS) refers to them as charactonym [4], indicating that the emphasis is placed on anthroponyms rather than on all other categories of onyms in a literary work [5, p. 94].

At the same time, the onomastics of Robin Hobb's novels remain largely unexplored in both domestic and international linguistics. Isolated references to this material can be found in fan communities and online forums dedicated to discussing 'The Elderlings', yet no scholarly studies have been identified that



systematically analyse Hobb's charactonyms from the perspective of literary onomastics. It is precisely this gap that the present article seeks to fill.

Aim of the article. The aim of this article is to conduct a functional-semantic analysis of charactonyms in Robin Hobb's novels from the 'World of the Elderlings' series, to identify typological groups of charactonyms, to establish their main functions, and to determine their role in character development and the construction of the works' imagery.

To achieve this aim, the following tasks are to be addressed: 1) to define the concept of a charactonym and clarify its characteristics in relation to the material of the analysed novels; 2) to describe the principles of constructing the onymic space of the 'World of the Elderlings'; 3) to classify the identified charactonyms into functional subgroups and carry out their semantic analysis.

Presentation of the main research material. A charactonym is a proper name (most often an anthroponym or toponym) in a literary work that creates and portrays a character, shapes the perception of that character, and influences the reader's attitude towards them. Unlike real proper names, a charactonym is always the result of the author's choice and therefore conveys certain information about the bearer: their social status, ethnic origin, character traits or role in the plot.

'The Elderlings' is a literary universe invented by the American writer Robin Hobb and described in several trilogies. This world is at the developmental stage of the early Middle Ages. All proper names of characters and geographical features belonging to the culture of the Six Duchies carry semantic meaning; that is, they are charactonyms in the full sense of the word.

A fundamentally important feature of the onymic space in the novels is its construction based on the principle of national-cultural contrast. Evocative, semantically charged names are used exclusively within the culture of the Six Duchies, which is linked to the concept of the magical power of a name, a central theme in Hobb's fictional world. In contrast, representatives of other peoples (mountain folk, outlanders, etc.) bear names with an unusual sound, which carry no semantic weight for the reader and emphasise the characters' cultural 'otherness'.

Researcher L. Belei [2] proposed a rigorous classification of the anthroponyms, dividing them into distinct functional-semantic subgroups: names of national or regional significance, socially significant charactonyms, and informational-evaluative names. Charactonyms of national (or regional) significance primarily serve to create the national flavour the author seeks in a work. In Hobb's novels, this subgroup is represented by the names of characters who do not belong to the culture of the Six Duchies. Their distinctive feature lies in the absence of semantic meaning coupled with phonetic 'foreignness', which in itself serves as a marker of foreign origin.



An example is the name Eyod – the reigning king of the Mountain Kingdom:

«Our Sacrifice, er, ah, you say, King Eyod will welcome you. And he will show to you all his daughter, to be your Sacrifice, hem, ah, Queen. And his son, who will rule for her here». She stumbled through this explanation, with many a pause, and many encouraging nods from me [6].

The name Eyod has no literal meaning, yet it stands out from the names of characters in the culture of the Six Duchies due to its phonetic unusualness. At the same time, the epithet shared by all members of the ruling dynasty is significant: Sacrifice – The Sacrificial One – which points to the symbolic role of the ruler in the culture of the mountain people.

The names of Prince Rurisk and Princess Kettricken are constructed in a similar way. The unusual nature of the name Kettricken is even emphasised in the characters' dialogue – King Shrewd cannot remember how it sounds, which is a telling detail:

«Almost I forgot to tell you why I had called you here. It is, of course, the mountain princess. Ketkin, I think her name was...» «Kettricken. I at least remember that much. A skinny little child, the last time I saw her. So, she is the one you have selected?» [6].

The case of a character named Burrich – a stablehand at the royal court, originally from Kalsid – is somewhat unusual. His name is also perceived as phonetically 'foreign', which emphasises his foreign origins. At the same time, researchers allow for partial semantic interpretation: the name may contain an allusion to the English word 'burr' (a thorn or bur), which correlates with the character's complex nature. This is the only instance in the novels where a 'foreign' name may have a hidden connotation.

Standard English names are almost entirely absent from the novels, and when they do appear, they belong mainly to members of the working class (Gill, Hod). The exception is the name Molly – the protagonist's beloved. Dictionaries record 'molly' as a colloquial/slang term for a girl or young woman, which gives grounds to regard this name as a charactonym with a tender, affectionate connotation, aptly characterising this woman's role in the protagonist's life.

Chronologically significant charactonyms are intended to situate a work within a specific time period. However, no examples with this function were found in the analysed novels. This is explained by the very nature of the work: the novels are based on entirely fictional events and characters in a fictional universe, so any reference to a real historical period would be incomprehensible to the reader and not perceived as significant.

Socially significant anthroponyms reflect the characters' social status, their origins and their role in society. It is this subgroup that is most prominently featured in Hobb's novels and most diverse in its manifestations.



One of the key examples is the name Chivalry – the eldest son of King Shrewd, heir to the throne of the Six Duchies:

And didn't Verity, after all, make a much better king-in-waiting than had Chivalry? So rigorously noble was Chivalry that he made all others feel slatternly and stingy in his presence; he'd never allowed himself a moment's respite from what was right, and while he was too chivalrous to sneer at those who did, one always had the feeling that his perfect behavior was a silent reproach to those with less self-discipline [6].

The word 'chivalry' is defined as 'the combination of qualities expected of an ideal knight, namely courage, honour, courtesy, justice, and a readiness to help the weak' (chivalry, nobility, bravery). The name Chivalry is not merely a description of a person, but also a social marker: it points to the ideal qualities of a knight-ruler and, at the same time, to the burden borne by a person who must live up to their own name.

A telling example in the context of social connotations is the name Regal – the king's younger son:

«When you talk about rogues who stay in bed all morning and do nothing except fuss about hair and garments, you mean how Regal is» [6].

The word 'regal' means 'of, resembling, or fit for a monarch, especially in being magnificent or dignified'. Regal is the third son and has little chance of inheriting the throne; however, his mother deliberately gave him a name that emphasises royal dignity, seeking to legitimise her son's claim to the throne. Thus, this name encodes not only the character's traits (arrogance, haughtiness) but also a social intention linked to the struggle for power.

A special place in the social onomastics of the novels is occupied by the name Fitz – the illegitimate son of Prince Chivalry, who is the main character:

Regal looked perplexed. «Him? It's the Fitz. Chivalry's bastard. Sneaking and thieving as always» [6].

The Urban Dictionary [7] defines 'Fitz' as 'means "son of"... but can also refer to an illegitimate child, a bastard, someone born out of wedlock'. Historically, the prefix 'Fitz' was used by the British monarchy to denote illegitimate offspring who were granted official recognition. In Hobb's work, this name functions as a social marker of dual nature: it simultaneously signifies recognition and disgrace, status and stigma. The choice of this charactonym for the protagonist is of fundamental importance to the entire plot and thematic structure of the novels.

Another significant social charactonym is The Fool – King Shrewd's court fool. This character's real name, origins and even gender remain a mystery throughout the entire cycle. His sole name in the eyes of the reader and most of the characters is his social function or role: The Fool. This is a charactonym where the social mask becomes the character's sole visible identity.



The names of the ancient kings are also socially motivated: Taker and Ruler, reflecting the nature of each monarch's reign. The author even specifically points out the nature of such naming:

A more ancient tradition attributes such names to accident, at least initially... But for the purposes of royalty, it is better to have the common folk believe that a boy given a noble name must grow to have a noble nature [6].

Descriptive-evaluative charactonyms serve to provide an emotional and expressive assessment of the characters. Hobb's novels feature exclusively informative-evaluative charactonyms, whilst no expressive-evaluative ones (where the evaluation is an end in itself) have been identified. This is consistent with the overall stylistic approach of the novels: the author strives for psychological depth rather than an external evaluative effect.

The most telling informational-evaluative charactonym is the name of King Shrewd. The characters repeatedly point out the correspondence between the name and the character:

«He is the King!» Molly protested. «And named Shrewd to be shrewd».

But our father the King is not a hasty man, as well we know. Shrewd is as Shrewd does, as the common folk say [6].

The word 'shrewd' means 'having or showing sharp powers of judgement; astute' (practical, intelligent, cunning). Shrewd is indeed an extremely pragmatic, and at times ruthless, ruler who views even his own grandson primarily as a pawn in the political game.

Lady Desire – the king's second wife – bears a name that encapsulates her defining trait: 'a strong feeling of wanting to have something or wishing for something to happen' (desire, passion, ambition). As queen, she was never satisfied with what she had achieved and always strove for more – power, recognition, and privileges for her son.

Patience – the wife of Prince Chivalry – is one of the novel's most profound characters. The word 'patience' means 'the capacity to accept or tolerate delay, problems, or suffering without becoming annoyed or anxious' (forbearance, tolerance). A woman who was unable to bear a child and had to endure the public revelation of her husband's bastard son, she eventually accepted Fitz and raised him as her own son. It is precisely her patience and capacity for forgiveness that are her defining traits, accurately reflected in her name.

Conclusions. The character names in Robin Hobb's novels form an integral part of the fictional world of 'The Elderlings'. They serve not only a nominative function, but also play a role in character development, social identification and cultural differentiation. The onymic space of the novels is constructed on the principle of national-cultural contrast: evocative, semantically rich names function exclusively within the culture of the Six Duchies, whilst characters from



other nations bear phonetically 'foreign' names without transparent semantics. The most prevalent are socially significant charactonyms (Chivalry, Regal, Fitz, The Fool, Taker, Ruler), which reflect the characters' social status, origin and role within the social hierarchy. This corresponds to the medieval setting of the novels, where name and status are inextricably linked. Informational and evaluative charactonyms (Shrewd, Desire, Patience, Chivalry) serve as psychological characterisations, revealing the inner essence of the character through the semantics of the name.

In most cases, the correspondence between name and character is not a coincidence but a conscious authorial device, emphasised by direct references in the text. Chronologically significant and expressive-evaluative charactonyms are absent from the novels, which is a natural consequence of the nature of a fantasy text with a completely fictional universe and a psychologically realistic approach to characterisation.

Areas for further research include extending the analysis to other cycles of "The World of the Elderlings", a comparative analysis of charactonyms in the original and in translations, and an examination of the toponymic level of the onomasticon in Hobb's novels.

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